# Lesson 25: Writing a Profile; Project Part 2: Personal Profile

*English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 2: Getting to Know You*

*Adapted from Getting to Know You - An Intermediate Integrated-Skills Module for English Learners by Sara Ferguson, Grossmont College (CC BY-NC-SA): Analyze a Profile; Analyze a Profile Key; Classmate Profile: Writing Assignment; and from Speaking, Listening and Pronunciation Projects for ELLs - Intermediate Level by Brittany Zemlick, Grossmont College (CC BY 4.0): Unit Project Part 2- Personal Profile.*

## In this lesson

You will look again at the profiles in this unit and find the common parts of a profile. Then you will interview your tutor's character from Lesson 21 a second time, write a profile about this person, and record a short spoken summary with clear -s endings.

## Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Say the type, focus and values of the profiles in this unit.
- Find the common parts of a profile.
- Write open-ended questions and follow-up questions to get more detail.
- Write a profile of one to two pages in the third person, with a positive tone.
- Give a spoken summary of 8 to 10 sentences with correct -s endings and linking.

## Key language

| Word or phrase | Meaning in simple English | Example |
|---|---|---|
| profile | a short text about one person and one part of their life | Student Spotlight--Meet Jennifer Moy |
| focus | the one part of the person's life that the profile is about | career, studies, art, hobby |
| caption | words under a photo | Leslie Reynolds, Chief Ranger, Cape Cod National Seashore, Massachusetts |
| quote | the person's own words, in quotation marks | "I consider myself very fortunate..." said Reynolds. |
| audience | the people who will read your text | Audience: other students |
| purpose | the reason you write | Purpose: to show readers an interesting life |
| open-ended question | a question that needs a long answer; often starts with how or why | Why do you like it? |

| Word or phrase | Meaning in simple English | Example |
|---|---|---|
| follow-up question | a new question about the answer the person just gave | What do you like to do in your free time and why do you enjoy it? |
| signal word | a word or phrase that connects ideas and shows time, order or contrast | Despite this, Jennifer chose Stony Brook University. |

## Rules and explanations

### The parts of a profile (the Leslie Reynolds profile)

1. **First sentence with the reason for the profile:** "Congratulations to the 2015 recipient of the Harry Yount National Park Ranger Award!"
2. **Photo and caption.**
3. **The "big picture" and the focus** (career, studies, art or hobby): her love of national parks.
4. **History and achievements** related to the focus: her 21-year career as a ranger.
5. **Current and future predictions, or wishes for success:** she continues to inspire new park rangers.
6. **A quote from the interviewee** about the focus. A quote is very common at the end of a profile.

### Good interview questions

- Start with background questions: name, place of birth, age.
- Ask **open-ended questions**. They invite a longer, more detailed answer. They often start with "how" or "why".
- Ask **follow-up questions**: "Do you like your job?" "Yes." "Why do you like it?"
- Be a good listener (Celeste Headlee's advice, Lesson 20).

### The spoken summary (Andy example)

The book's summary about Andy gives background (name, where he is from, where he lives), hobbies, food, job and values. It uses the third person -s many times: he lives, he cooks, he works. Mark the -s endings and the links in your summary, as in Lesson 23.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic letters have no capital form. In English, start every sentence and every name of a person, city, country, school or company with a capital letter: Andy, Oxford, San Diego, Stony Brook University.

## Practice

**1. Type of profile.** You met these profiles in Lessons 17 to 20. Is each one an employee/intern profile, a student profile, or a profile of a famous person? Think about who published it. Leslie Reynolds · Cody Gibson · Jennifer Moy · Felipe Valdez · Brandon Stanton · Diana Nyad

**2. Focus.** Write the focus of each profile. Choose from: career accomplishments and goals; educational accomplishments and goals; artistic process; passion (a strong interest).

**3. Values.** Match the people (Diana Nyad, Felipe Valdez, Brandon Stanton, Cody Gibson, Jennifer Moy) with the values (learning about people; adventures and travel; designing buildings; strength and persistence; research in mechanical engineering).

**4. What is a profile?** Choose one answer in each pair. A profile is about (a) one person / many people. It is (b) short / long. It has (c) a person's whole life history / a few facts about the person's history. It focuses on (d) one part of a person's life / everything that is important to that person. It has (e) a negative tone / a positive tone. It is about (f) someone famous / anyone.

**5. Analyze the Jennifer Moy profile.** Read "Student Spotlight--Meet Jennifer Moy" in your lesson material. Find the same parts as in the Reynolds profile. Which parts are missing?

**6. Analyze Andy's summary.** Read the Example Transcript about Andy in your lesson material. Take short notes: Background (name, from, lives); Hobbies; Food (eats / does not eat); Job (job, every day, why he likes it); Values; Other.

**7. Second interview.** Your person is the tutor's character from Lesson 21. Tell the tutor the person's name and job from your notes (see "Speak with your tutor"). a) Ask: What is your full name? Where and when were you born? What is your current living situation (who do you live with and where)? What do you think are the two most important events that happened in your life? Tell me about two activities that interest you most. b) Write 15 open-ended questions about the answers to the last two questions. c) Ask them, with follow-up questions. Take notes and record the conversation on your phone. d) Put your notes in the same table as exercise 6.

**8. Spoken summary.** Write 1 or 2 paragraphs (at least 8 to 10 sentences). Include the person's name, what the person does in the job every day, free time activities, and what the person values most in life. Mark the -s endings and the links. Practice, memorize and record a video of yourself, looking at the camera. Show one picture that helps us understand the story (a photo or a drawing). Listen, note your mistakes, and record again.

## Speak with your tutor

- "Please play the person I interviewed before: [name], a [job]. Here are my notes: [read them]. Stay in this role and answer my new questions in detail."
- "Ask me five follow-up questions about my notes, so I know what more to ask."
- "Listen to my spoken summary. Tell me which -s endings I missed and where I can link words."
- "Here is my profile. Does the first sentence show the focus? Is the name in the first or second sentence? Did I use two signal words? Is the tone positive?"

## Read aloud

- Andy is from Oxford, but he lives in San Diego. (↘) (lives /z/)
- He also cooks, plays the guitar, and listens to podcasts. (↘) (cooks /s/, plays /z/, listens /z/)

- He avoids eating meat. (↘) (avoid-zeating)
- Every day he works outside. (↘) (work-soutside)
- Andy teaches other farmers about sustainable agriculture. (↘) (teaches /ɪz/, farmers /z/)

## Writing task

Write a profile of the person you interviewed (your tutor's character). Use your notes.

- **Length:** one to two pages, double-spaced (about 250 to 500 words if you type).
- **Audience, genre, purpose:** other English learners; a profile; to show readers this person's interesting life.
- **Content:** Focus on one positive part of the person's life (an education goal, an important life experience, an important value). Include at least two of these: the history of the person's achievements; a description of the person's life in the past or present; a photo; a quote from the person.
- **Organization:** Start with a sentence that shows the focus. Put the person's first name in the first or second sentence. Use at least two signal words.
- **Style:** a formal, positive and friendly tone; the third person (the name, he or she); your own words.
- **Grammar:** the tenses you need (present simple and continuous, past simple and continuous, future) and different kinds of sentences. Check capital letters, punctuation and spelling.
- Make notes or a mind map before you write.

## Answer key

**1.** Reynolds: employee (National Park Service). Gibson: student ("Student Spotlight"). Moy: student ("Student Spotlight"). Valdez: intern (NASA). Stanton: famous person. Nyad: famous person.

**2.** (suggested answers; you may choose differently if you can explain why) Reynolds: career. Gibson: educational. Moy: educational (book: the focus is on her choices related to education). Valdez: educational. Stanton: artistic process. Nyad: passion.

**3.** Nyad: strength and persistence. Valdez: research in mechanical engineering. Stanton: learning about people. Gibson: adventures and travel. Moy: designing buildings.

**4.** a) one person, b) short, c) a few facts, d) one part of a person's life, e) a positive tone, f) anyone.

**5.** (book) Focus: her long commute and the city's architecture suggest the focus, her choice of major. History: from the Bronx to Brooklyn, her high school, her college, her major, her library job. Wishes for the future: she is ready to graduate by May 2021; "We're looking forward to that day Jennifer!" Quote: "I grew up in a city full of towers and skyscrapers..." Photo and caption: "Jennifer Moy". Missing: the opening "hook", a first sentence that tells the reader why this person is in the profile.

**6.** Background: Andy; from Oxford; lives in San Diego. Hobbies: reading, running, cooking, playing the guitar, listening to podcasts. Food: no meat, because meat production hurts the environment. Job: farmer; works outside, plants and waters crops, pulls weeds, harvests, repairs fences, teaches other farmers about sustainable agriculture; loves working outside. Values: protecting the environment (in the Lesson 15 video: his family and making the world a better place). Other: drives a pickup truck.

**7.** (example answer) Why did you choose this job? How did your family help you? Why is your family so important to you?

**8.** (example answer) Lina Haddad is from Amman, but she lives /z/ in Dubai now. She is a nurse in a children's hospital. Every day she checks /s/ on her patients and talks /s/ to their parents. She loves /z/ her job because she helps /s/ children feel better. In her free time, she reads /z/ novels and plays /z/ tennis. She avoids /z/ eating fast food because she wants /s/ to stay healthy. Her family is the most important thing in her life. She believes /z/ that kindness changes /ɪz/ people. In the future, she hopes /s/ to open a small clinic.

## My notes